

Solomon's seal is mostly used for throat and chest problems.



Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Europe and to temperate regions of Asia and North America, Solomon's seal is quite rare in the wild. However, it is a common ornamental garden plant. The rhizome is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used

Rhizome.
Constituents Solomon's seal contains steroidal saponins (similar to diosgenin), flavonoids, and vitamin A.

History & Folklore Solomon's seal has been used in Western herbal medicine since classical times. In China, the herb's first recorded use stretches back to the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ngong Bencaojing*) of the 1st century CE. In North America, the species *P. biflorum* was known to various native tribes. The Penobscot used Solomon's seal as part of a formula for treating gonorrhea.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Like arnica (*Arnica montana*, p. 172), Solomon's seal is believed to prevent excessive bruising and to stimulate tissue repair. The rhizome, which is mainly used in the form of a poultice, has astringent and demulcent actions that undoubtedly contribute to its ability to accelerate healing. Solomon's seal has also been recommended for tuberculosis, as a remedy for menstrual problems, and as a tonic. In Chinese herbal medicine, it is considered a *yin* tonic, and is thought to be particularly applicable to respiratory system problems—sore throats, dry and irritable coughs, bronchial congestion, and chest pain.

Related Species Angular or scented Solomon's seal (*P. odoratum*) is used in much the same way as *P. multiflorum*.

⚠ **Caution** Do not take internally except under professional advice. The aerial parts, especially the berries, are harmful if eaten.

Polygonum aviculare (Polygonaceae)

Knotgrass, Bian Xu (Chinese)

Description Annual creeper growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has lance-shaped leaves and clusters of small pink or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Knotgrass is found in temperate regions throughout the world. It thrives on wasteground and along shorelines. The plant is gathered throughout the summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Knotgrass contains tannins, flavonoids, polyphenols, silicic acid (about 1%), and mucilage.

History & Folklore Knotgrass has been used as a diuretic in Chinese herbal medicine for over 2,000 years. In the Western tradition, the 1st-century CE physician Dioscorides likewise considered knotgrass to be a diuretic, as well as a remedy for heavy menstrual bleeding and snake bite.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An herb with astringent and diuretic properties, knotgrass is used in European herbal medicine to treat many conditions—diarrhea and hemorrhoids, to expel worms, to staunch bleeding wounds, to reduce heavy menstrual flow, and to stop nosebleeds. Knotgrass is also taken for pulmonary complaints, since its silicic acid content strengthens connective tissue within the lungs. In Chinese medicine, it is given to expel tapeworm and hookworm, to treat diarrhea and dysentery, and as a diuretic, particularly when urination is painful.

Research Chinese research indicates that the plant is a useful medicine for bacillary dysentery. Of 108 people with this disease treated with a paste of knotgrass (taken internally), 104 recovered within 5 days. Results from Iranian laboratory studies indicate that knotgrass stimulates apoptosis (programmed cell death) and might be of use in treating breast cancer.

Related Species See also bistort (*P. bistorta*, following entry), and he shou wu (*P. multiflorum*, p. 124).

Polygonum bistorta (Polygonaceae)

Bistort

Description Perennial growing to 12 in (30 cm). Has long basal leaves, dense spikes of small pink flowers, and dark nutlets.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, Asia, and North America, bistort prefers damp conditions. The leaves are gathered in spring, the rhizome in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, rhizome.

Constituents Bistort contains polyphenols (including ellagic acid), tannins (15–20%), phlobaphenes, flavonoids, and a trace of the anthraquinone emodin.

History & Folklore Bistort rhizomes have long been employed for their astringency. As the rhizomes also contain large amounts of starch, they have been steeped in water, roasted, and eaten as a vegetable in Russia and North America. In addition, the young, tender leaves of bistort may be used in salads or, alternatively, cooked in the same way as spinach (*Spinacia oleracea*).

Medicinal Actions

& Uses One of the most strongly astringent of all herbs, bistort is used to contract tissues and staunch blood flow. It makes a valuable mouthwash and gargle for treating spongy gums, mouth ulcers, and sore throats, and is also useful as a wash for small burns and wounds, a douche for excessive



Rhizome

Bistort is one of the most astringent of all medicinal plants.